matter of weeks, the situation had deteriorated so rapidly that the entire British contingent of nearly 17,000 men, women and children were forced rapidly to evacuate the capital. During their retreat towards India through the treacherous gorges and snowbound passes, almost the entire party died of either starvation, cold or at the hands of local tribesmen. The event was a military and diplomatic disaster for Britain, and one that would long remain in the conscience of the public, immortalised as it was in Lady Butler's painting, The Remnants of the Army, which depicts Dr William Brydon, said to be the sole survivor of the Kabul cohort.[7] *It was this shocking turn of events in Afghanistan that, some have argued, caused the British to realise that the Great Game could, in fact, never be won by them. Instead, they would simply spend the rest of the nineteenth century trying not to lose.*[8]

However, this argument suffers from certain flaws, not least of which pertains to the Second Anglo-Afghan War (1878–80), which arguably successfully achieved what Britain had failed to do the first time around. In July 1878, under pressure from Russia, the then emir, Sher Ali, had reluctantly agreed to allow a Russian mission to reside in Kabul, a move which angered Britain even further when their own mission was denied entry into the country. The viceroy of India, Lord Lytton, 'determined to teach the Emir a lesson he would not easily forget, and at the same time make it perfectly clear to St. Petersburg that Britain would tolerate no rivals in Afghanistan'.[9] By May 1879, with large parts of his country under British occupation, the emir's son and successor, Yakub Khan (Sher Ali having died a few months previously), signed the Treaty of Gandamak. By its terms, the new emir agreed not only to cede certain territories close to the Indian frontier to Britain, but, more importantly, relinquished control of Afghanistan's foreign relations to British India.[10] The parallels with the first Afghan conflict are striking – yet again it had been precipitated by British fear of Russian machinations in Afghanistan and a zealous British governor general in India. Unfortunately, Britain had apparently failed to learn the lessons of the 1840s, however, and yet again the British resident sent to Kabul, Major Cavagnari, would soon be massacred by an angry Afghan mob.[11] From 1880 until 1920, no British mission would be kept on Afghan soil. Nevertheless, for the next forty years Britain would retain control of Afghanistan's foreign relations. By the Anglo-Russian Convention of 1907,